

# API Versioning Strategies

**Day 3 handout.** The "evolve without breaking" guarantee. Three common strategies, their trade-offs, and the default. Pick one and document it — "we don't need versioning yet" defers a cost rather than removing one.

| Strategy            | Where the version lives                            | Pros                                 | Cons                    |
|---------------------|----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|-------------------------|
| URL path            | <code>/v1/...</code> <code>/v2/...</code>          | Easy to read; clear breaking changes | Code duplication        |
| Header              | <code>X-API-Version: 2</code>                      | URL stays clean                      | Less discoverable       |
| Content negotiation | <code>Accept: application/vnd.acme+json;v=2</code> | Standard                             | Often poorly understood |

## The default

For most B2B APIs, **URL path versioning** is the right default. It's the most discoverable and makes breaking changes explicit.

## Document your choice

**Versioning strategy:** \_\_\_\_\_

**Rationale:** \_\_\_\_\_

Force the strategy choice **now**. Deferring it doesn't remove the cost — it just moves it to the first time you need a breaking change, when it's more expensive.